exclusively through the ministry of external affairs. But I did not want an ‘outsider’.

Seshan worked around this problem and ensured that I got the man I wanted, Unni, a trusted stenographer from Vikram Sarabhai Space Centre. Unni, proved to be much more than that. He meticulously documented our meetings, filed and tucked away drawings and documents, and ensured that our dispatches went back to India without being opened even by the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) officials.

Our team members came in batches, most of them with their young wives. I brought along my wife, five-year-old son and three-year-old daughter. By September, the team of sixty was in place. We decided to meet at the office conference hall after the first day at SEP. The first meeting wasn’t a happy one. Every one found out of place at SEP, and we realised that without learning French, our mission will be useless. Our men could not even exchange pleasantries with the French. After a crash course by Berlitz School of Language, however, our scientists were bubbling with confidence.

The first challenge to the joint venture came in early 1975, a few months after we had set up base in SEP, as the European Space Agency (ESA) was founded with the merger of the European Space Research Organisation (ESRO) and the European Launcher Development Organisation (ELDO). ESRO was formed in 1964 with ten European countries to do scientific research in space. It stemmed from the previously existing CERN, the European Organisation for Nuclear Research.

ELDO had come into existence after the British Blue Streak Missile Programme was called off, and as a joint venture to develop the Europa satellite launcher. When the satellite programme failed to show results, the two organisations merged to form the ESA.

Soon after taking over as the first director general of ESA, Roy Gibson, a British technocrat who was ESRO director till then, wanted an amendment to the ISRO-SEP contract on Viking. He wanted the part of a clause that said ISRO should use the technology ‘for its own use’ be changed to ‘for its own peaceful use’.